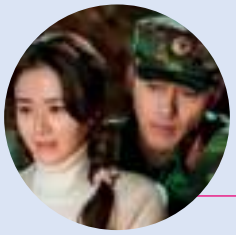
K-DRAMA

A SERIES OF MASTERPIECES

Many a heart has been satiated by the chaste romances dominating modern K-drama, but there's more to the industry than rooting for cute couples. See *Squid Game*, a hair-raising thriller where the bodies pile up in a gladiatorial fight for riches, or *Glory*, a revenge drama about a woman who decides to bite back at her childhood bullies in the most twisted ways imaginable. In 2024 itself, Korean was the second-most watched non-Indian language on Netflix after English. A few titles that exemplify India's addiction to the genre





- **The Legend of the Blue Sea (2016)**
- **Guardian: The Lonely and Great God (2016)**
- **Descendants of the Sun (2016)**
- **What's Wrong with Secretary Kim (2018)**
- **Crash Landing on You (2019)**
- **Flower of Evil (2020)**
- **Itaewon Class (2020)**
- **It's Okay to Not be Okay (2020)**
- **Hospital Playlist (2021)**
- **Business Proposal (2022)**
- **Glory (2022)**
- **Extraordinary Attorney Woo (2022)**
- **Squid Game (2021-25)**

media and entertainment industry confirms that Korean, Japanese and Spanish shows are the most-watched non-Indian language content on Netflix after English. In fact, Season 1 of Netflix original *Squid Game* remained in its Top 10 for 39 weeks. Following its success, Netflix announced in 2023 that it would spend $2.5 billion over the next four years to develop Korean content. Other streaming giants like Amazon Prime and Disney+ Hotstar are also expanding their Korean slate. Platforms like Playflix are dubbing K-content in Hindi, Tamil, Telugu and Kannada.

GIMME GOCHUJANG

Food is an intrinsic part of most Korean shows, where local cuisine is celebrated effortlessly. It is around food that tough conversations unfold, families bond and hearts connect. Indian viewers, too, want to slurp *ramyeon* (Korean noodles) or down *soju* (a rice-based alcoholic beverage) like the three best friends in *Thirty-Nine*, or share Woo

THE RESPECT FOR FAMILY, HIGH CHASTITY QUOTIENT AND A SHARED FEAR AND NOSTALGIA FOR A SEVERED SIBLING-NATION MAKE K-DRAMAS POPULAR IN INDIA

Young-woo's love for *gimbap* (seaweed rice roll) in *Extraordinary Attorney Woo*. ARMY brat Asees Kohli perhaps developed her love of Korean cuisine through Korean drama. A pastry chef in Jammu, Asees dove into Korean cuisine with gusto, even enrolling in a six-month language course at the Korean Cultural Centre in Delhi so that she could read recipe books. "Korean restaurants became my regular haunts because I wanted to compare and see if my dishes tasted authentic," says the 27-year-old. "I've now been to every Korean restaurant in Delhi NCR."

Korean cuisine has opened up a whole new culinary world for the Indian foodie. With bold, fermented flavours like *kimchi* and *gochujang*, Korean dishes—low on oil, rich in spices and mostly grilled or boiled—sit comfortably on the Indian palate. *Ramyeon*, a comfort food for Koreans, has made its way into Indian kitchens, clocking 56 per cent growth according to consumer intelligence firm NielseniQ. In Mumbai's Mahavir Nagar, it is not unusual to see a *ramyeon* mobile cart serving packets of Buldak Ramen and Nongshim, while nearby, HighCha serves *bingsu*, a Korean dessert made of shaved ice and sweet toppings. In Delhi too, Korean food and culture are firmly woven into the urban fabric, with Korean fashion boutiques and eateries lining neighbourhoods like Hauz Khas Village, Majnu Ka Tila and Humayunpur.

Taking note of this shift, Indian